

Grocery giants spar after a ruling

Albertsons says it is ending merger plan and accuses Kroger of not doing enough to secure deal's approval.

By QUEENIE WONG

When Kroger and Albertsons announced plans in 2022 to team up on what would be the largest supermarket merger in U.S. history, the two grocery store chains highlighted their shared values.

Now their relationship has turned sour, with each side blaming the other for the demise of what would have been a landmark deal.

A day after a federal judge temporarily halted the merger, Albertsons said Wednesday that it's scrapping the controversial pairing and suing Kroger, alleging that the chain failed to do enough to win over regulators.

Once partners, the grocery chains are now accusing each other of breaching the merger agreement and acting in their own interests.

The fallout between Kroger and Albertsons and the failed merger raise fresh questions about the future of their businesses and the effect on people who shop at their stores. The companies, which have a big presence in California and nationwide, banked heavily on the benefits of joining forces to better compete with the likes of Walmart, Costco and Amazon.

"Anytime you get these two companies fighting with each other, that's money that could be used for innovation and to better position themselves in the market," said Christine Bartholomew, a law professor at the University at Buffalo.

The legal battle between the major grocery chains is the latest development in what has been a tumultuous two years for Albertsons and Kroger as they tried to win government approval for their megamerger. In February, the Federal Trade Commission sued to block Kroger's proposed \$24.6-billion acquisition of Albertsons because of concerns that it would eliminate com-

[See [Merger](#), A7]

FBI chief will quit next month

Christopher Wray says he'll leave before his 10-year term ends, to avoid a showdown with Trump. [NATION](#), A4

Dodgers prepare to defend title

They finish week with strong roster for 2025, hoping to add Japanese star pitcher Roki Sasaki, 23. [SPORTS](#), B10

Get state cash to buy an e-bike

California is offering qualified residents up to \$2,000 toward the purchase of an electric bike. [BUSINESS](#), A6

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BRIAN VAN DER BRUG Los Angeles Times

AN L.A. COUNTY helicopter drops water on the Franklin fire in Malibu as a crew works nearby Tuesday. More than 1,500 firefighters were battling the blaze and it was 7% contained as of Wednesday afternoon.

Crews struggle to tame Malibu blaze

Firefighters 'are working tirelessly around the clock' as Franklin fire threatens more neighborhoods.

By KAREN GARCIA, HANNAH FRY, NATHAN SOLIS AND CLARA HARTER

A fire that has burned homes in Malibu and forced thousands to evacuate continued to menace the city Wednesday as firefighters battled windy conditions to gain control over the inferno.

The Franklin fire has destroyed at least seven homes and damaged nine others since it ignited amid strong Santa Ana winds late Monday. Fire officials say those numbers could grow as inspection teams continue to assess damage.

The blaze, which has charred more than 4,000 acres and was 7% contained as of Wednesday afternoon, burned close to some residential neighborhoods and an RV park overnight, L.A. County Fire Chief Anthony Marrone said during a morning news conference.

"Crews are working tirelessly around the clock to establish containment lines and defend structures," Marrone said.

The blaze was reported a few minutes before 11 p.m. Monday along Malibu Canyon Road in the hills north of Pepperdine University and grew quickly, fanned by strong winds and fed by bone-dry vegetation, fire officials said.

Overnight into Wednesday, the fire's western edge became more active, backing down into Corral Canyon toward the Malibu RV park community. The fire also spotted across Pacific Coast Highway toward Malibu Road, posing a threat to communities in that area, according to the California

[See [Malibu](#), A10]

At Pepperdine, a tense fire scene

Following university policy, students are told to shelter in place as flames approach Malibu campus. [CALIFORNIA](#), B1

County hate crimes hit new high in '23

A man in San Pedro shouted a racial slur and chucked a glass bottle at a Black bus driver on her break. A trans woman getting off the Metro in Koreatown was told she belonged in hell. A father on his way to a Tarzana synagogue was interrupted by a man threatening to "kill all of you Jews."

The grim encounters were among the record-breaking number of hate crimes reported across L.A. County last year, an increase fueled by an onslaught of harassment directed at Jewish, Black and LGBTQ+ people, according to a county report released Wednesday.

The report from the county's Commission on Human Relations found 1,350 reported hate crimes — up 45% from the year before. It's the highest level since the commission began counting in 1980.

"I will tell you, I was shocked to learn that," said Robin Toma, the commission's executive director, at a news conference Wednesday announcing the findings.

Toma called the figure "historic,"

Report tallies 1,350 allegations of criminal bias — an increase of 45% from the year before

By REBECCA ELLIS

and said it was potentially a result of better outreach by the commission and rising levels of vitriol directed at the county's minorities.

Hate crimes across the county have been trending up since 2014, but the commission's tally of more than 1,300 incidents last year marked a significant jump. In 2022, 930 incidents were recorded.

The previous high was 1,031 reported hate crimes in 2001, the year of the Sept. 11 attacks.

"It is unacceptable," Sheriff Robert Luna said of the latest numbers. "I promise you as the sheriff of this county that we are going to respond."

Nathan Hochman, who was elected district attorney last month after campaigning on improving public safety, rebuked his predecessor, George Gascon, saying he'd failed to prosecute hate crimes. Hochman pledged to "send an increasingly clear message to the hate criminals."

"I don't see prosecution here," he said. "I don't see consequences."

[See [Hate crimes](#), A5]

Defiance toward order to close juvenile hall

By JAMES QUEALLY AND REBECCA ELLIS

A top Los Angeles County probation official has said the agency won't obey a state order to vacate Los Padrinos Juvenile Hall this month, potentially setting up a costly showdown between state and county officials and prompting threats of legal action from defense attorneys.

"We're not moving," Chief Deputy Probation Officer Kimberly Epps told a group of several dozen probation officers last month, according to a recording provided to The Times. "You're going to have to put our stuff on the curb."

Probation officials have not publicly signaled their plans, but a refusal to vacate Los Padrinos would defy the California Board of State and Community Corrections, which ordered the Downey facility shut by Thursday unless the county could improve staffing levels. A spokesperson for the state oversight board confirmed Monday that the Probation Department failed a last-chance inspection be-

[See [Probation](#), A10]

TRUMP'S L.A. GAINS

Crime, economic worries weighed on Asian American voters

While Arcadia and Temple City remained solidly blue, many frustrated residents decided Trump deserved another chance

By REBECCA ELLIS

After months of waffling, longtime Democrat Edmund Liu swung to Donald Trump because of the smash-and-grab down the street.

When Liu first moved to the U.S. from China, he was drawn to the Democratic Party because he saw it as immigrant-friendly.

But he began to question his allegiance after more than a decade in Arcadia, an affluent suburb at the foot of the San Gabriel Mountains that is home to many Asian immigrants. The tab for celebratory dinners with his extended family often

approached four digits, and his paycheck as a software engineer wasn't stretching as far as before.

Then, about a week before the Nov. 5 election, he saw videos on social media of people in black hoodies running with handbags out of a secondhand luxury store in the Westfield Santa Anita mall while a security guard recorded passively.

"It's about five minutes driving from my home, and it is like one minute of driving from the Police Department. I was like, 'That's ridiculous,'" said Liu, 55. "I was like, 'OK, I made up my mind, and that's it.'"

This year in the Arcadia and [See [Voters](#), A5]



GENARO MOLINA Los Angeles Times

THE MANAGER of Tang Gong restaurant in Arcadia said she hopes Donald Trump will help bring back bustling lunch hours.



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